What a School Leader Can Do

Opening the school between leadership and learning

Paper idea for discussion. October 2026

A school runs on its leadership.

What does a school leader actually change, and how far does it reach?

How teachers teach, work together, and feel about their work. How classrooms are run. How families take part. And, through all of this, how pupils learn. We know leadership matters. We do not know what it does.

What we know

Leaders matter	A one SD better principal raises achievement by 0.05 to 0.10 SD (Branch, Hanushek, and Rivkin, 2012; Böhlmark, Grönqvist, and Vlachos, 2016). The effect is comparable to a teacher's, over a whole school (Grissom, Egalite, and Lindsay, 2021).
Changes matter	When the principal changes, achievement falls by about 0.03 SD the next year and teacher turnover rises (Bartanen, Grissom, and Rogers, 2019).
Leadership and the school	Where teachers value their principal's instructional and relational leadership, schools show better climate, more collaboration, better classroom management, higher wellbeing and job satisfaction (OECD, TALIS 2018). Correlational.

What has been opened, and what has not

Personnel	Effective principals keep their best teachers and lose their weakest (Grissom and Bartanen, 2019, AERJ). Principals reshape the staff through hiring and retention (Bartanen and Grissom, 2023, JHR). Who teaches in the school is the channel the literature has identified.
Procedures	For superintendents, better leaders change school priorities, working procedures and violence (Lavy, Boiko, and Rachkovski, 2023, EJ).
Not yet seen	Under a change of leader the school did not choose: what the same teachers do and how they feel, how classrooms are run, and how families respond. The inside of the school.

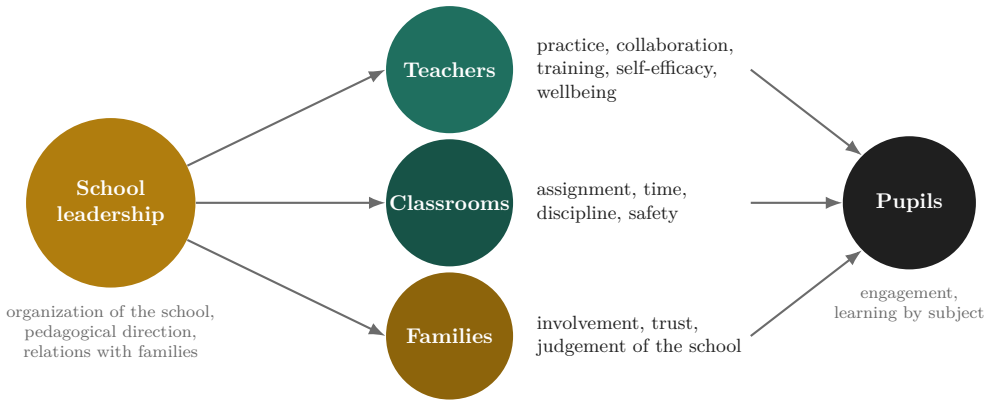
The literature shows that leaders matter and that they choose who teaches. This paper is about what they do with the teachers they have.

What a school leader shapes

Teachers	How they teach, how they collaborate, what training they take, how confident and how well they feel. Each an outcome in itself: the working life of a profession.
Classrooms	Who teaches which group, how time and support are used, how discipline is handled, whether pupils feel safe.
Families	Whether they are involved, whether they trust the school, how they judge the teachers and the centre.
Pupils	Engagement, perceptions of their school, and learning by subject.

A leader reaches pupils through the first three. Teachers and families are not intermediate steps: they are what a school is made of, and they are outcomes we care about.

Causal map



Every node is observed, for every school in Madrid. The first arrows are the ones we identify.

Why Madrid lets us see it

Leadership through people	Spanish principals are teachers elected by their colleagues for four-year terms. Staffing, pay and curriculum are set by the administration, so a principal leads through the organization of the school, the direction of teaching, and the relation with families. What changes when the leader changes is leadership itself, on the same staff.
Timing set by rule	Terms end by compulsory retirement at 65 and by a limit of twelve years in office, fixed years in advance. Leadership changes arrive on a calendar, not in response to how the school is doing.
The successor is known	New principals come from the same staff: we observe them as classroom teachers the year before they take office.
The whole school is observed	Every public primary school in Madrid, 2015 to 2018: the principal, each teacher, each classroom, every pupil and every parent, with standardized scores by subject.

Identification: a principal's clock



Treated Schools whose clock runs out in 2016, 2017, or 2018: a new leader arrives for reasons unrelated to the school's trajectory.

Comparison Schools whose clock runs out later. Staggered event study on the calendar; 2SLS for the realized change.

Benchmark Exits that are not rule-based (resignations, non-renewals), kept separate: they carry the selection the literature worries about (Miller, 2013; Bartanen, Grissom, and Rogers, 2019).

Who arrives The successor's practices, wellbeing and views, measured before office; the committee's grade of their project; the staff's rating of the outgoing principal.

Counts

What we would test, in the order a leader reaches it

Outcome	What a new leader may change	Measured with	When
Classrooms	Assignment of teachers and support hours across groups	Schedules, class composition	Year 1
Classrooms	Discipline and climate	Pupil and teacher reports	Years 1–2
Families	Involvement, trust, judgement of the school	Parent survey	Years 1–2
Teachers	Self-efficacy, wellbeing, collaboration, training	Teacher survey	Years 1–2
Teachers	Classroom practice of the same teachers	Teacher survey, within teacher	Years 2–3
Pupils	Engagement and learning, by subject	Pupil survey, standardized tests	Last

Preregistered indices by domain. Pupils come last: a leader reaches them through the rest.

What we can learn

How much	What a change of leadership does to each node of the map: teachers, classrooms, families, pupils. The cost, or the gain, of a transition that nobody asked for.
Whether leaders differ	If the identity of the leader matters, outcomes disperse more after a rule-based exit than in an ordinary year (Jones and Olken, 2005). This needs no judgement of who is good.
What good leadership is	Which incoming leaders move the school, using only what was known before they took office: how they taught, what they proposed, how their predecessor was rated.

Together: not only that leadership matters, but what it consists of.

Data

In hand	Universe of Madrid public primary schools, 2015 to 2018. Principal questionnaire. Teachers: practices, wellbeing, training. Schedules: who teaches which class. All pupils by classroom: scores by subject, perceptions. All parents by classroom: involvement, satisfaction.
To collect	Principal appointments, renewals, and exits with cause (BOCM). The committee's grade of each project. Teacher assignment lists: chosen versus imposed posts. School plans from archived websites. Public school-level results from 2022: the long run.
Rotation	136 principals selected and 36 unplanned vacancies in 2016–17 across 1,156 public centres; 336 changes in 2017. Roughly 400 to 500 changes in primary over the three transitions, of which the rule-based subset is to be counted.

Three things to decide

- **Which parts of the school a new leader reaches first.** Of the nodes on the map, which do we believe move in year one, and which take longer?
- **What the data must have.** A stable teacher identifier across years; the principal's age and years in office; the survey items that rate the principal.
- **How many rule-based exits there are** in 2015 to 2018, and whether the Consejería can add appointment records and later years.

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Backup: how much rotation is there?

Year	All public centres (1,156)
2016–17	136 principals appointed through selection; 36 unplanned vacancies (retirement, transfer, resignation, no candidate)
2017	336 changes of principal; 47 direct appointments by the administration (14%)

Sources: Comunidad de Madrid press release, 2016; Diagonal, 2017 (secondary). Primary schools are about 800 of the 1,156 centres. The rule-based subset (age 65, twelve-year cap) is to be counted in the panel from the principal's age and years in office.

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